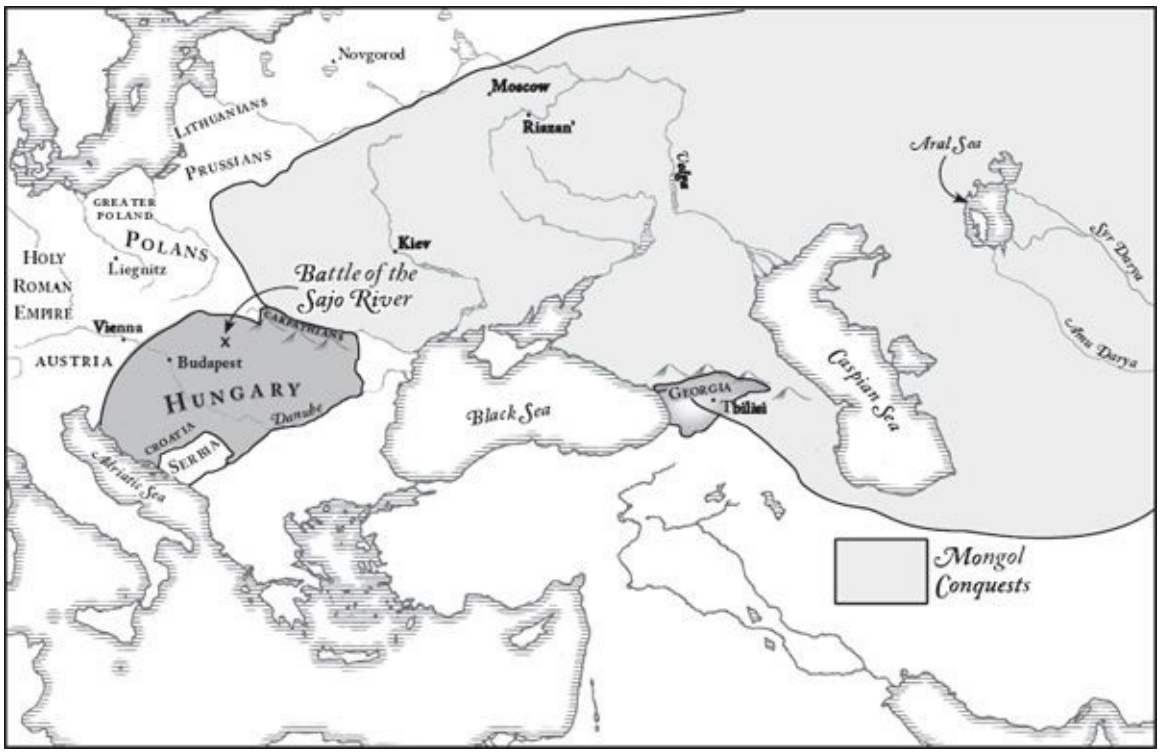
Late in 1237, Subotai and Batu crossed the Volga; the Mongols were accustomed to fighting in the bitter cold, and the frozen countryside posed no challenge to them. A breakaway strike force, commanded by the veteran general Chormaghan, veered to the south and crossed the Caucasus range into Georgia. Already battered by the Mongols in 1219, Georgia now lost its capital city, Tbilisi, and most of its eastern reaches; the Georgian nobles were pressed into the Mongol ranks.[9]

Meanwhile, Subotai and Batu had terrified the first Rus' city in their path. They captured Riazan' on December 21, just before the Christmas Mass. "They burned it all," says the contemporary *Voskresensk Chronicle*, "and killed its prince and his princess, and seized the men, women, and children, and monks, nuns, and priests; some they struck down with swords, while others they shot with arrows and flung into the flames." Moscow fell, as did Kiev after a ten-week siege; so many panicked Kievans crowded into the Church of the Tithe, hoping for safety, that the second floor gave way and the church collapsed inward. Six years later, a traveler passing through Kiev made note of the skulls and bones still piled on the deserted streets.[10]



45.2 Mongol Conquests in the West

By 1240, all of the Rus' principalities except for Novgorod, the most distant, were under Batu's rule; his nonexistent inheritance had finally been fleshed out with captives. Subotai, after resting his army, pressed on in the